Cut the Rope: how players are receiving the game

Player sentiment, Jan–Aug 2026 (v3.x, before the update) vs Sep–Oct 2026 (v4.x, after the migration update). Google Play and App Store reviews, YouTube, Reddit and forums. Data pulled 3 Nov 2026.

4.52 → 4.24
Google Play rating, all raters (Play Console, 30-day avg), Jan–Aug vs Sep–Oct

4.26 → 2.91
Avg ★ of written Google Play reviews (vocal players), same periods

13% → 44%
Share of 1★ among Google Play written reviews

3% → 40%
Reviews saying "the update ruined it / bring back the old one"

Executive summary

- **The 4.0 migration is the biggest change in player sentiment this year, and it is negative.** The real Google Play rating (Play Console, all raters) held at 4.45–4.61 from January to July. It slid as the rollout grew, reaching 4.16 in mid-October, the lowest in 12 months, and averaged 4.24 in Sep–Oct against 4.52 in Jan–Aug. It is still above 4★. Players who write reviews are far harsher (Play 4.26 → 2.91, iOS 3.34 → 2.35). In the same weeks of the partial rollout, v3.x reviewers gave 4.1★ and v4.x reviewers 2.8★, so the drop comes from the update, not from seasonality.
- **Before the update, players were fond of the game but unhappy about ads.** 59% of reviews praised it as fun or relaxing and 20% mentioned childhood or nostalgia, while 27% complained about ad volume. Ads were the price players paid, and the core game was loved.
- **After the update, the complaint moved from "too many ads" to "you changed the game I loved".** Five things are new and specific to 4.x: you **can no longer replay or choose levels** (1% → 17% of reviews), **lives / limited attempts** (1% → 14%), an **AI-generated look and app icon** (0% → 8%), a feeling that the game is now **"pay-to-play" or greedy** (2% → 6%), and **UI clutter and pop-ups** (1% → 5%). Praise for fun fell from 59% to 28%.
- **Reviews that blame ads went down, not up** (27% → 19%). This is consistent with fewer interstitials per DAU after the switch to MAX (3.11 → 2.29) and with the 2-day no-interstitial gift for migrated players. The monetization grievance has moved to lives and coins instead.
- **YouTube amplifies the story to an audience far larger than the review stores.** The two videos you shared have about 735k views and 2.4k comments, and a third adds 30k views. Weighted by upvotes, the top themes are "update ruined it" (37%), the **AI icon** (27%, with commenters pointing out a visible Gemini watermark), blame on ZeptoLab as "corporate greed" (17%), and lives (11%). Players compare ZeptoLab to Rovio and share workarounds: old APKs, CTR GOLD and the HD versions.
- **Critical change between versions:** negative reviews went from 23% to 60%. The anger is not limited to veterans: reviews with and without a "long-time player" signal are equally negative (62% vs 59%). That contradicts the internal reading that the backlash comes "mostly from migrated users", at least among people who write reviews.

What is driving the shift, in order of impact

#	Driver	Evidence	Status internally
1	Lives / limited attempts on a trial-and-error puzzle	14% of v4 reviews; 11% of YouTube upvote weight; top comment with 1.3k likes: “like adding lives to Super Meat Boy”	No decision found
2	No level select / replay; progression gated by stars and 3-level stages	17% of v4 reviews; support ticket from a parent who used to replay levels with their child	Asked internally, unanswered
3	AI-made icon and art ("AI slop", "Cut the AI")	8% of reviews; 27% of YouTube upvote weight; Gemini watermark visible on the icon	Art team suggested replacing it; not scheduled

#	Driver	Evidence	Status internally
4	"Pay-to-play" perception: coins, Play Pass, pop-ups, events you can’t opt out of	6% of reviews plus the UI pop-up complaints (5%)	4.4.0 adds banners and a loss offer, which may make this worse
5	Bugs at end of content (black screen at level 190/191), migration losses	3–4% of reviews	Planned for 4.4.0

1. Sources and method

Source	What was collected	Volume (Jan 1 – Nov 2, 2026)
Google Play (com.zeptolab.ctr.ads)	All written reviews in 11 languages (en, ru, es, pt, fr, de, id, tr, it, ko, ja), with app version	5,344 reviews
App Store (id1024506959)	Public review feed, 18 storefronts (feed capped at about 500 most recent per country)	908 reviews
YouTube	157 videos about the game published in 2026 found; comments pulled from the 15 most relevant (incl. both reference videos)	3,276 comments (2,462 labelled: top-level comments plus replies with 5+ likes)
Reddit & forums	Reddit via public archive (reddit.com blocks direct access); web forums via search	See section 6
Internal context	Slack: #ctr-unity-dev, -release, -analytics, #evergreen-studio-leads, support	Rollout dates, known issues, roadmap

Periods. A = Jan–Aug 2026 and B = Sep–Oct 2026, as requested. The Android partial rollout ran 22 Jul–15 Sep (1% → 100%) and iOS ran 15–22 Sep, so August is mixed. As a robustness check we also compare v3.x and v4.x reviewers within the same weeks (22 Jul–14 Sep), using the app version Google Play attaches to each review.

Coding. A 26-code topic list was built from a stratified sample of 300 reviews (Sonnet). Every review and comment with at least 15 characters was then labelled with topic, polarity, sentiment, whether it mentions the update, and whether the reviewer signals being a long-time player (Haiku, 4,990 reviews and 2,462 comments). An independent check of 60 random labels (Sonnet) found sentiment and update-mention 100% correct, topic precision 96% and recall 95%, with no error large enough to bias the A-vs-B comparison. All period differences reported as "significant" pass a two-proportion z-test at $p<0.01$.

Limitations. (1) Topic analysis uses *written* reviews, and angrier players write more. The size of the effect on the real rating comes from the Play Console export (all raters). The iOS rating trend is not yet included because App Store Connect data was not available. (2) Discord was not covered: it needs a logged-in export. (3) Confluence design docs were not readable (connector not authorized); 4.x mechanics are taken from Slack and from what players describe. (4) YouTube transcripts were blocked, so videos are analysed through their comments. (5) One review containing a possible safeguarding disclosure was excluded and flagged separately.

2. Ratings: a step change in September

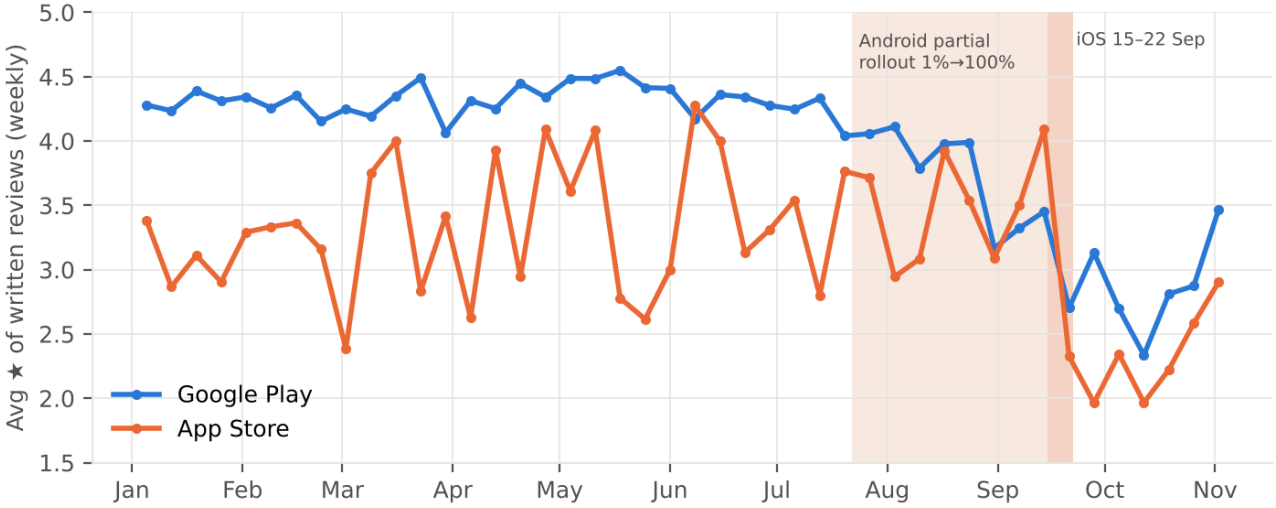
2a. The real rating: everyone who rates (Google Play Console).



Play Console, average rating as a 30-day rolling daily average. Shaded: Android partial rollout. Dotted lines: period averages.

The global rating lost about 0.3★: from 4.52 on average in Jan–Aug to 4.24 in Sep–Oct, with a low of 4.16 on 13 Oct. That is the lowest level in the past 12 months, but still above 4★. The decline follows the rollout steps: about 4.42 at 30% (24 Aug), 4.28 at 100% (15 Sep), 4.16 by mid-October. Since 4.3.0 (23 Oct) it has recovered slightly, to 4.21–4.22. **The US is largely unaffected**: 4.02 in Jan–Aug and 4.01 in Sep–Oct, and it already swung between 3.6 and 4.3 earlier in the year with no update. So the global drop is driven by other markets. The US did dip from 4.13 to 3.56 between 22 Jul and 6 Aug, during the 1–5% stage. Slack describes that stage as excluding the US, while the Console notes say "171 countries". This is worth checking.

2b. Players who write reviews. Written reviewers are a small and much more critical subset, so their averages run well below the Console figure. They show the same timing, at much larger amplitude, and they explain *why* (sections 3–5).



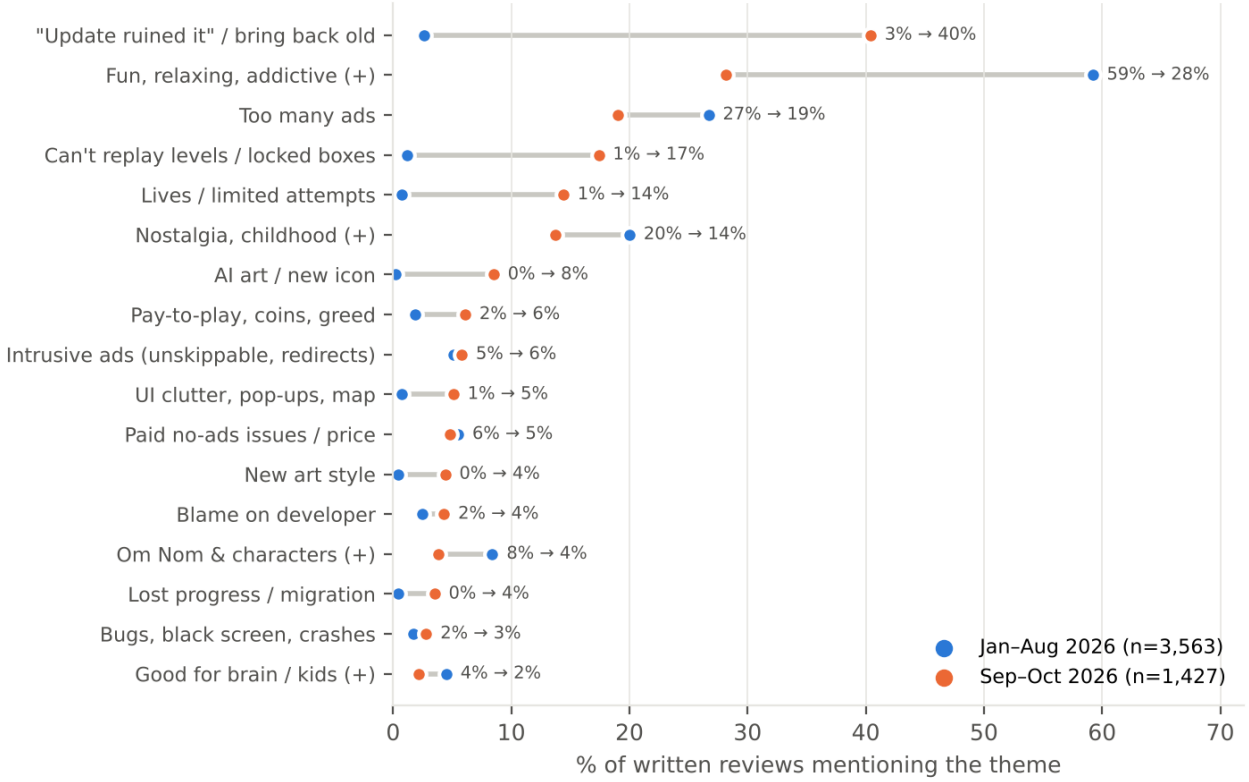
Weekly average stars of written reviews (weeks with at least 8 reviews). Shaded: rollout windows. iOS is noisier because volume is lower.

Platform · period	Reviews	Avg ★	1★ share	5★ share
Google Play · Jan–Aug	4,061	4.26	13%	74%
Google Play · Sep–Oct	1,240	**2.91**	**44%**	40%
App Store · Jan–Aug	551	3.34	30%	46%
App Store · Sep–Oct	351	**2.35**	**55%**	24%

Platform · period	Reviews	Avg ★	1★ share	5★ share
Play, same weeks (22 Jul–14 Sep): v3.x reviewers	303	4.07		
Play, same weeks (22 Jul–14 Sep): v4.x reviewers	197	**2.76**		

Reading. Play written reviews were remarkably steady from January to July (4.15–4.49 every month), then dropped as v4 reached more players: 3.73 in August, 3.08 in September, 2.75 in October. The decline is the same in every major language: English 3.60 → 2.24, Russian 4.15 → 2.87, Spanish 4.36 → 3.09, Portuguese 4.25 → 3.18. The first days of November show a partial recovery on Play (about 3.4), after 4.3.0 shipped on 26 Oct with Super Om Nom and Sweet Challenge restored. It is too early to call that a trend. iOS was already lower before the update, mainly because of ads and complaints about paid no-ads.

3. What players praise and what they criticise



Share of written reviews (Play + iOS) mentioning each theme. Blue = Jan–Aug, orange = Sep–Oct. A review can mention up to 4 themes.

What players praise (stable core)

- **The core puzzle is loved.** "Fun, relaxing, addictive" is the most common theme overall (59% of reviews before the update). Players praise short levels, satisfying physics and the escalating difficulty.
- **Nostalgia is a huge asset.** 20% of pre-update reviews reference childhood ("I played it at 5", "the theme of my 7th birthday party"). After the update the same feeling turns into grief: "you ruined my childhood game".
- **Om Nom and the art style** (8%), and the game being **good for kids and the brain** (5%). Parents are a visible segment, and **offline play** (planes, kids) is valued.

  “When I was a kid, I loved this game. As I became older, the view never changed!!” — Play, Mar 2026, 5★

  “Excellent game! It gets harder as you go, but it’s really fun. I love the music, the look and the very well-designed mechanics.” — Play, Mar 2026, 5★, translated from Spanish

What players criticise, Jan–Aug (v3.x)

- **Ad volume** is the dominant complaint (27%): an interstitial after every level or retry, and "more ads than gameplay". Players turn off wifi as a workaround.
- **Intrusive ads** (5%): hard-to-find close buttons, redirects to the store, long unskippable ads.
- **Paid no-ads problems** (6%): "I paid and still get ads" (rewarded ads, ads for other games), the $9.99 price, and subscription confusion. This is also the top theme on iOS.

  “The amount of ads is horrendous. Every time you wanna retry a level? Ad. You beat a level? Ad. You die? AD!” — App Store, Feb 2026, 1★

  “This app is an ad-watching simulator with a few touches of gameplay in between.” — Play, Mar 2026, 1★, translated from Spanish

What players criticise, Sep–Oct (v4.x)

- **"The update ruined it / bring back the old version"** (40%). Many name no specific feature; they are reacting to the game no longer feeling like itself.
- **Can’t replay levels; locked boxes; must 3-star to progress; 3-level stages** (17%).

- **Lives / limited attempts / limited candy** (14%), seen as a contradiction for a trial-and-error puzzle and as a push to watch ads or pay.
- **AI-generated art and icon** (8%), **new art style** (4%), **UI clutter and pop-ups** (5%). Migrated players get many feature pop-ups in their first session.
- **Pay-to-play / greed** (6%), **blame on the developer** (4%), **lost progress or purchases** (4%), **black screen at level 191** and changed physics (3%).

  “You can’t replay levels, there is a lives system, and if you move the bouncy pad to the other side of a conveyor and it hits the candy, it breaks?! They really ruined it.” — Play, Sep 2026, 3★

  “The new limited lives and pay to play mechanics take a once loved game and make it joyless.” — Play, Sep 2026, 1★

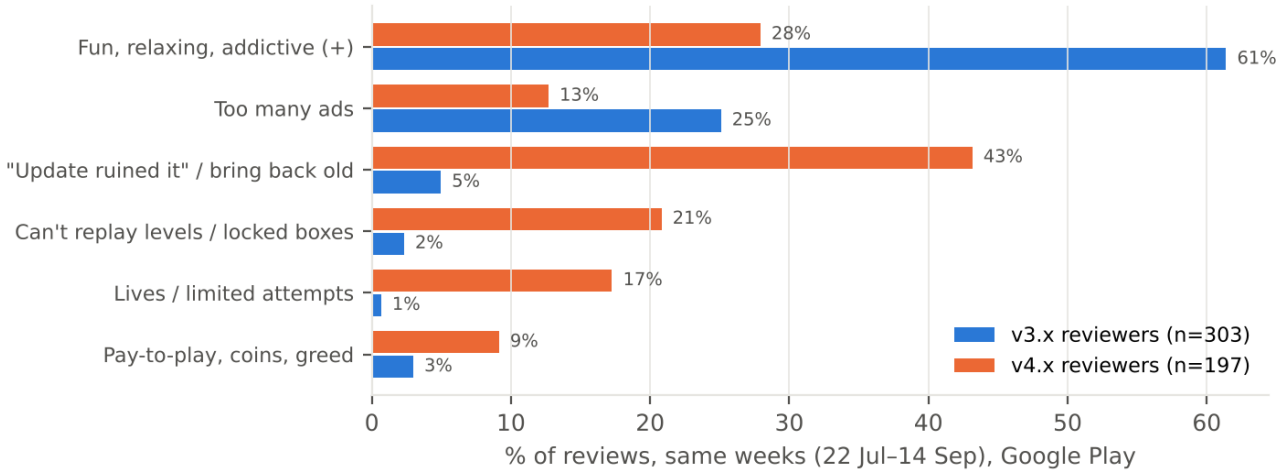
  “AI Slop. Latest update is just full of AI slop. The new icon is even generated by Gemini, how lazy can you be...” — App Store, Oct 2026, 1★

  “This game was great 10 years ago when I first played it. Now I had to go past 10 different pop-ups... Just let me play the damn game and stay out of my way.” — Play, Oct 2026, 1★

  “I kept this app only for flights on flight mode. But with the new update even that’s not possible anymore... the life system destroyed what was left of the game.” — Play, Oct 2026, 1★

4. What critically changed between the two versions

To separate the update from calendar effects (season, country mix, featuring), the chart compares Google Play reviewers on v3.x and v4.x **in the same weeks** of the partial rollout.



Change	Jan–Aug	Sep–Oct	Verdict
Negative overall sentiment	23%	60%	**Critical**, ×2.6
Praise for fun / relaxing	59%	28%	**Critical**: the core promise is no longer felt
"Update ruined it / bring back old"	3%	40%	**Critical**, new
Level access / replay / star gating	1%	17%	**Critical**, new, design-driven
Lives / limited attempts	1%	14%	**Critical**, new, design-driven
AI art / icon	0%	8%	**High**: small in stores, dominant on YouTube
Pay-to-play / greed	2%	6%	**High**, rising
UI clutter / pop-ups	1%	5%	Medium
Lost progress / migration	0.4%	4%	Medium (bugs ticketed)
Too many ads	27%	19%	Improved (also crowded out by other topics)
Paid no-ads issues	6%	5%	Unchanged
Nostalgia (+)	20%	14%	Lower, and turning into grief

Who is upset? Not just veterans. Among Sep–Oct reviews, those that signal a long history with the game ("since childhood", "used to") are 62% negative, and all the others are 59% negative. We cannot separate brand-new installs in review text (very few say "just downloaded"), so the internal view that new users like 4.x may still hold among people who don't write reviews. That is a question for retention and rating data, not for reviews.

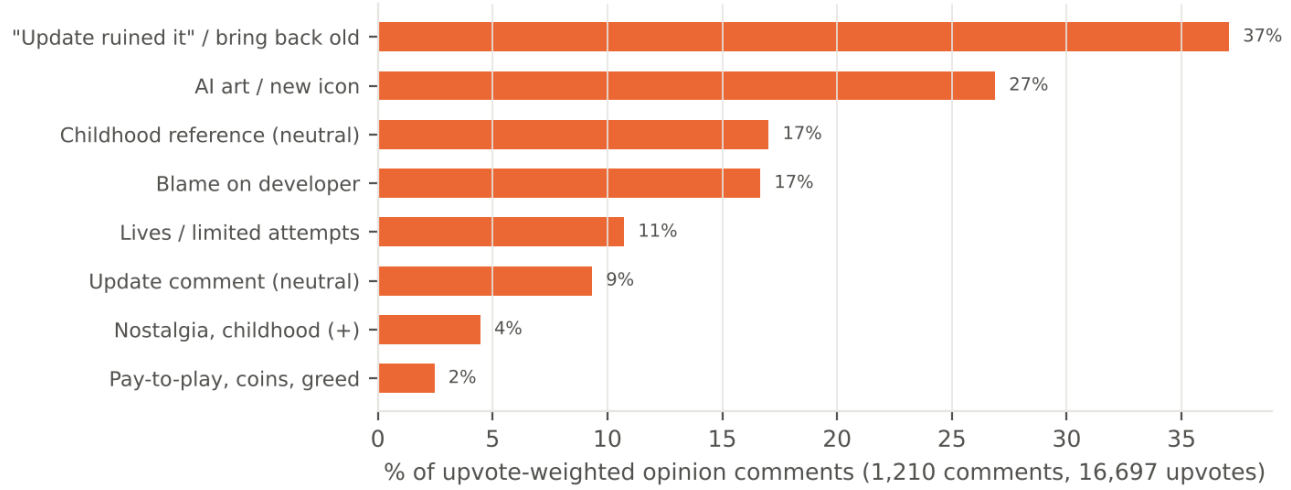
What 4.3.0 changed. Restoring Super Om Nom and Sweet Challenge (26 Oct) did not produce a visible wave of positive reviews. Play reviews in the first days of November are higher (about 3.4★ on 100 reviews), but the sample is too small to attribute.

5. YouTube: where the narrative is being written

YouTube reaches far more people than the stores. The update-focused videos have more than 765k combined views and are almost uniformly negative (71% of opinion comments are negative, only 8% positive). Pre-update videos (cutscene evolutions, challenge runs) have neutral-to-warm comments about Om Nom and nostalgia.

Video	Channel	Published	Views	Comments
You Won't Believe What Just Happened to Cut the Rope	SnipeSnap	7 Oct	571k	1.4k

Video	Channel	Published	Views	Comments
Cut The Rope Is Being Replaced...	Cut the Rope Home	27 Sep	164k	973
Do NOT Download These Fake Cut the Rope Games...	SnipeSnap	29 Oct	116k	197
Reviews Are In For The Horrible Cut The Rope Update	Cut the Rope Home	11 Oct	30k	302
Why everyone hates the new cut the rope update / Ads RUINED This Game...	smaller creators	Oct	1–4k	<10



Themes in opinion comments on the update videos, weighted by likes, so they reflect what the audience endorses.

- **The AI icon is the YouTube story.** The most-liked specific comment (1.5k likes) points out the Gemini watermark visible on the icon. "Cut the Rope → Cut the AI" is a recurring meme. In stores it is only 8% of reviews, but on YouTube it carries 27% of the upvote weight. It is also the cheapest item on this list to fix.
- **Industry framing.** Commenters put ZeptoLab in a "ruined childhood games" series with Angry Birds/Rovio, PopCap and Minion Rush ("The game is not for you or for fans. It is for shareholders.", 396 likes).
- **Lives are the most-cited mechanic** ("Cut the Rope does NOT work with limited lives considering how hard it can be. It's like adding lives to Super Meat Boy", 1.3k likes).
- **Players are routing around the update:** old APKs on Android, CTR GOLD, the HD versions, Time Travel. The "fake Cut the Rope games" video shows clones taking advantage of the confusion.

  "2026 is truly a bad year for my childhood games" — top comment, SnipeSnap video, 2.3k likes

  "We, yes... WE, are switching to an outdated version of Cut the Rope (that doesn't have the AI slop)" — Cut the Rope Home video, 800 likes

6. Reddit, forums and Discord

Coverage here is thin, and this section should be read as a gap, not a finding. reddit.com blocks automated access from this environment. The public Reddit archive rate-limited every text search. TouchArcade and the Cut the Rope Fandom wiki were unreachable, and web searches for 4PDA, GameFAQs, ResetEra and Spanish/Portuguese forums returned nothing from 2026. r/cuttherope itself has been inactive since Sep 2025.

The one thread captured (r/mobilegaming, 16 Sep: "Anyone else feeling uncomfortable with Cut The Rope's New UI?") repeats the store themes: the new UI and lives ("Wait we have lives now!? Nah bro", "its horrific", "Ya no le ponen ganas", Spanish for "they don't put effort into it anymore").

Discord was not covered. Its messages require a logged-in export (e.g. DiscordChatExporter, Jul–Oct). If the community team shares one, it can be labelled with the same topic list and added to this report in under an hour. We would expect it to over-represent veterans and the level-select and lives themes.

7. What we are accepting as-is, what we plan to act on, and open decisions

Cross-referenced against Slack decisions and the 4.3/4.4 scope as of 3 Nov 2026. "Accepting as-is" means a known complaint we are deliberately not changing, usually because of monetization.

Accepting as-is (deliberate, mostly monetization)

Complaint	Player weight	Why we keep it / note
Ad frequency (interstitials after levels and retries)	27% → 19% of reviews; still the #1 single complaint before the update	Core revenue. Already softer in 4.x (impressions/DAU 3.11 → 2.29). Watch the effect of 4.4.0 banners.
Rewarded ads still shown after buying No Ads	Part of 5–6% "paid but still see ads"	By design (the offer removes forced ads). **Cheap mitigation:** clearer offer copy and restore messaging; currently "Nothing to restore" confuses buyers.
No Ads price ($9.99)	Recurrent on iOS	Price restored 27 Oct after the 5.99 error.
4.x is easier / slightly different physics	<2%	No rebalancing during migration (decision). Low player weight.
Longer load / loading screen	<1% of reviews	Optimisation partly in 4.4.0; low player weight.
Not replying to reviews	—	No bandwidth. Consider templated replies to the top 1★ themes to signal listening.

Planned / in progress

Issue	Player weight	Plan
Super Om Nom, Sweet Challenge missing	small, veterans	Shipped in 4.3.0 (26 Oct)
End of content at level 190/191 (black screen)	~1–2% of Sep–Oct reviews	4.4.0
Migration bugs (compensation gift, catch-up, double coins)	4% "lost progress"	CTRU-3197, 3204–3209 being triaged for 4.4.0
Build size and load time	low	Parallel init in 4.4.0; download-on-demand only if offline risk is mitigated

Not addressed: decisions needed

Issue	Player weight	Why it matters	Suggested option
Lives / limited attempts	14% reviews; 11% YouTube	Conflicts with the trial-and-error core; the most-cited "greed" signal	Test generous or no lives in early boxes, or for migrated veterans
No level select / replay	17% reviews	Removes a habitual behaviour (parents replaying with kids, replay for stars)	Re-enable replay of completed levels
AI-generated icon and art	8% reviews; 27% YouTube	Reputational: visible watermark, "Cut the AI" meme	Replace the icon with a hand-made one (art team already proposed it)
Pop-up flood / forced events for migrants	5% reviews	Every feature triggers at once on the first session	Stagger feature intros for migrated players
4.4.0 banners + loss offer	risk	Adds to the "ad-infested pay-to-play" narrative at its peak	Gate behind A/B; watch the 1★ share

8. Recommendations

- **Fix the cheap, high-signal items first:** replace the AI icon, clarify the No Ads copy and restore flow, and stagger the migration pop-ups. These address roughly a third of the specific v4 complaints with little revenue risk.
- **Decide on lives and level replay with data.** They are the two design changes players single out. A/B test (a) no lives for migrated veterans, or lives only after box N, and (b) replay of completed levels. Measure the effect on retention, ad ARPDAU and the 1★ share.

- **Track the real rating as the KPI.** On Google Play it fell about 0.3★ (to a 12-month low of 4.16) but stays above 4★. Add the iOS equivalent, and set a guardrail (e.g. global Play rating < 4.15) for 4.4.0. The US dip during the early 1–5% rollout also needs explaining.
- **Sequence 4.4.0 carefully.** Banners and a loss offer land while the "greedy" narrative is still active on YouTube. Ship them behind an A/B with a rating guardrail.
- **Respond publicly once.** A short "we hear you" note in the store listing or a pinned YouTube or community post, listing what has been restored (Super Om Nom, Sweet Challenge, prices) and what is next.